



Fetal Surveillance Testing

Special monitoring tests to check your baby's health

Why may special tests be needed during pregnancy?

Special testing during pregnancy most often is done when there is an increased risk of pregnancy complications or stillbirth. This can occur in the following situations:

- High-risk pregnancy (a woman has had complications in a previous pregnancy or has a pre-existing health condition such as diabetes mellitus or heart disease)
- Problems during pregnancy, such as fetal growth problems, Rh sensitization, or high blood pressure
- Decreased movement of the fetus
- Pregnancy that goes past 42 weeks (postterm pregnancy)
- Multiple pregnancy with certain complications

When during pregnancy are special tests performed?

Special testing usually is started between 32 weeks and 34 weeks of pregnancy. Testing may be started earlier if problems are particularly serious or there are multiple risk factors.

How often are special tests done?

How often the tests are done depends on the condition that prompted the testing, whether the condition remains stable, and results of

the testing. Some tests are repeated weekly. In certain situations, tests may be done twice weekly.

What are the types of special tests?

The tests used to monitor fetal health include fetal movement counts, the nonstress test, biophysical profile, modified biophysical profile, contraction stress test, and Doppler ultrasound exam of the umbilical artery.

What are fetal movement counts?

If you have felt fetal movement less often than what you think is normal, your health care professional may ask you to keep track of the

fetus's movements. Fetal movement counting (also called "kick counts") is a test that you can do at home. There are different ways kick

counts can be done. Your health care professional will tell you how often to do it and when to notify him or her.

What is a nonstress test?

The nonstress test measures the fetal heart rate in response to fetal movement over time. The term "nonstress" means that during the

test, nothing is done to place stress on the fetus.

How is the nonstress test performed?

This test may be done in the health care professional's office or in a hospital. The test is done while you are reclining or lying down and

usually takes at least 20 minutes. A belt with a sensor that measures the fetal heart rate is placed around your abdomen. The fetal heart

rate is recorded by a machine.

What do the results of a nonstress test mean?

If two or more accelerations occur within a 20-minute period, the result is considered reactive or "reassuring." A reactive result means

that for now, it does not appear that there are any problems. A nonreactive result is one in which not enough accelerations are detected in

a 40-minute period. It can mean several things. It may mean that the fetus was asleep during the test. If this happens, the test may last

40 more minutes, or the fetus may be stimulated to move with sound projected over the mother's abdomen. A nonreactive result can

occur if the woman has taken certain medications. It also can